

upskilling must be prioritised. The foundation for sustained economic growth rests on fiscal policies, infrastructural investments, and also on the mobilisation of women into the workforce and the commitment to enhancing the skill sets of the entire working population.

The female labour force participation rate has reached 37 per cent in 2023, per the Periodic Labour Force Survey Report 2022-23. This increase signifies a positive shift towards greater economic inclusion and empowerment of women, fostering a more diverse and dynamic labour landscape. Further, by investing in the development of skills and promoting a culture of lifelong learning, India can not only enhance the productivity of its labour force but also ensure its adaptability to the rapidly evolving economy.

This dual strategy will not only fortify the foundation of economic growth but also drive a transformational wave of innovation and efficiency across industries. I be-

lieve this convergence of increased female participation and a skilled workforce will undoubtedly propel the nation towards its ambitious GDP target.

USHERING IN A NEW ERA

India's progress towards achieving greater gender diversity in corporate boardrooms is commendable, but we still have a long road ahead. To harness the economic and strategic benefits of gender diversity, ongoing initiatives to promote women into leadership roles are imperative.

Organisations have the opportunity to deploy an array of strategic initiatives. Foremost among these is the launch of mentorship and leadership development programmes, specifically designed to support and nurture female professionals. Such programmes represent a pivotal facet of empowerment, providing women with the essential skills and confidence required to ascend to leadership positions within the

corporate hierarchy.

Secondly, the implementation of flexible work policies stands as a critical imperative. These policies serve as a cornerstone for achieving an enhanced work-life equilibrium, with a particular emphasis on supporting women who often navigate caregiving responsibilities. By giving women professionals the flexibility to manage their professional commitments alongside their personal obligations, these policies will help augment their proclivity to pursue and excel in leadership roles.

Furthermore, companies can proactively stimulate gender diversity by actively endorsing the establishment of networking and support groups exclusively tailored to women professionals in leadership roles. These forums provide an invaluable platform for women professionals to exchange experiences, extend guidance, and nurture each other's professional development.

India's remarkable progress in boosting gender diversity within corporate boardrooms is a product of both regulatory interventions and a growing appreciation of the pivotal role diversity plays. The path to greater representation for women is not without challenges, yet it is a journey with promise, potential, and the reshaping of businesses into dynamic, inclusive, and ultimately successful entities.

This transformative journey isn't just about balancing numbers; it's about harnessing the power of diverse perspectives to drive innovation, foster resilience, and create corporate cultures where everyone's voice is not just heard but valued. It is a narrative of change that not only benefits businesses but also society at large, setting the stage for a more equitable and progressive Bharat. **BT**

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